COURSE & INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Course

Course Title, Prefix, Number, Section: DCDA Capstone, DCDA40833.015 & 035

Semester and Year: Spring 2025

Number of Credits: 3 hours credit

Course Component Type: RES

Class Location: NEEL 1208 & REE 219

Class Meeting Day(s) & Time(s): 9:30 and 11:00 TR

Instructor

Instructors Names: Dr. Curt Rode & Dr. Sean Crotty

Office Location: Schar 2006 (Rode) | Schar 2004c (Crotty)

Office Hours: https://calendly.com/c-rode/appointments (Rode) |
2 to 3 pm Tuesdays (Crotty)

Preferred Method of Contact: Email

Email: c.rode@tcu.edu (Rode) | sean.crotty@tcu.edu (Crotty)

Response Time: less than 48 hours

Final Evaluative Exercise & Important Dates

FINALS: TBD

Note for students: The syllabus is your first course reading. It provides an orientation to, overview of the flow, and expectations of the course. You should turn to the syllabus for details on assignments and course policies.

Student Resources & Policy Information

Click or scan QR code for resources to support you as a TCU student. Please note section on Student Access and Accommodation, Academic Conduct & Course Materials Policies, and Emergency Response & TCU Alert.

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COURSE DESCRIPTION

Catalog Description

This course is designed as a capstone experience for students in the Digital Culture & Data Analytics (DCDA) Minor. Hence, the course is designed to give students the

opportunity to develop a semester long project that will allow them to practice, reflect upon, and publicly showcase their work as students in the DCDA program.

Prerequisites & Concurrent Enrollment

MATH 10043 or INSC 20153 and GEOG 30323, WRIT 20833, or COSC 10603

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

Exemplar, creative, and critical texts, assigned as needed. Unless otherwise noted, readings and links to most resources will be provided through D2L.

Additional costs related to the course. There are no upfront costs for this course, as we plan to use free, open-source software in most of our training. That said, students may choose to purchase software (the Adobe suite, Tableau, MAXQDV, etc) specific to their needs for their Semester Projects. Some of this software may be available through a TCU license on specific machines, though, so please check with us before purchasing.

Supplementary Resources

We hope you'll see your instructors and your classmates as the best resources for the course. If you need additional support for the work you'll complete for the course, please contact:

Center for Digital Expression (CDEx) (cdex@tcu.edu, Scharbauer 2003)

Center for Writing (817-257-7221, Reed Hall 419)

TEACHING PHILOSOPHY & METHODOLOGY

We usually begin our course introduction by saying, *"If class time is spent with only the instructors talking, this course is going to suck for all of us."* So, to that end, our main ambition is for each student to have a growing confidence in their ability to engage in the course material. Our role is to provide as much useful context as possible to get the discussion and your Semester Projects *started*. Whatever we bring to the conversation, **we want the students to push each other and themselves** to take the conversation and their projects *further*. We'll all learn more – and you'll have a lot more fun in the process -- if we're exploring the course materials, tools, and issues together.

Early in the semester, class time will be spent in discussion, demonstrations, and lab assignments intended to help you refine the skills needed for your Semester Project. As the semester moves on, more and more class time will be spent on tasks directly related to your Semester Projects.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

Course Learning Outcomes

1. Students will be able to choose and apply proper statistical methods for analysis and interpret the results of their analysis.
2. Students will demonstrate an ability to compose digital arguments.
3. Students will encounter significant works of scholarship and/or methods for doing research in digital studies.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS

Assignments

The first half of the course will allow you to update your digital skills toolbox and/or give you practice using tools you might incorporate into your Semester Project. This part of the course requires weekly assignments (or **labs**) that will culminate in a **DCDA Skill Portfolio & Midsemester Reflection.**

The second half of the course will allow you to focus on developing (solo or in a group) a **Semester Project** that takes a "deeper dive" into a topic of your choosing broadly connected to digital culture and/or data analytics. To prepare for the final draft, we'll ask roughly midsemester that you submit a **Project Proposal (w/ Bibliography).** Closer to the end of the semester, we'll also ask that you submit at least 1 if not 2 **Rough Drafts**.

While we want you to be able to use your **Skill Portfolio** and your **Semester Project** for your next steps, post-graduation (as part of job or grad school applications, for example), we encourage you to explore topics that venture firmly outside narrow professional interests. Our reasoning: you'll spend the better part of the rest of your life as a "professional" of some sort. Consider approaching this class as one of your "last" opportunities, at least as an undergraduate student, to explore a topic of personal interest, you know, for its own sake.

Grading Philosophy & Policy

Ungrading

(Adapted with much gratitude from Jesse Stommel's syllabus available here: https://dgst101.com/dgst101-fall-2020-syllabus-302b22518009)

This course will focus on qualitative as opposed to quantitative assessment, something we'll discuss during the class. While you will get a final grade at the end of the term, we will not be grading individual assignments, but rather asking questions and making comments that engage your work rather than simply evaluating it numerically. You will

also be reflecting carefully on your own work and the work of your peers. The intention here is to help you focus on working in a more organic way, as opposed to working as you think you're expected to. If this process causes more anxiety than it alleviates, see us at any point to confer about your progress in the course to date. If you are worried about your grade, your best strategy should be to attend class, join the discussions, do the readings, and complete all the assignments in a timely manner. All this said: **you should consider this course a "busy-work-free zone." If an assignment does not feel productive, talk to us about ways we can modify, remix, or repurpose the instructions.**

Your grade for the semester will the average of 2 equally weighted grades.

The **first grade** will be based on the case you build for the grade you believe you deserve for the work you've done in the first half of the semester in the context of the feedback given you over the first 8 weeks. You'll make this argument in your **Midsemester Reflection**. ***Please grade yourself using the +/- system.***

The **second grade** will be based on the case you build for the grade you believe you deserve for the work you've done in the second half of the semester in the context of the feedback given over the second 8 weeks. You'll make this argument in you **Final Course Reflection.** Dr. Crotty and Dr. Rode will meet to discuss your arguments for your grades and reserve the right to adjust your grades based on the persuasiveness of your case. Your actual grades may be higher or lower than the grade you give yourself. ***Please grade yourself using the +/- system.***

Late Work

Which takes us to **Late Work**: Our schedule is tight, and you have some meaningful and important work to do. In the context of our Ungrading policy, we see assignment deadlines as milestones to keep you on track for the Skill Portfolio and Semester Project.

"Failure" to submit your work in a timely fashion will affect our ability to provide timely and needed feedback on your work and could affect the persuasiveness of the arguments you make for your midterm and semester grades.

One exception: Given that most students in the class are graduating seniors, late Semester Projects and Final Reflections will not be accepted. Our turnaround to report grades will be especially tight, and we won't have the time to track down late submissions of these final assignments.

In the event of an emergency or serious illness, every reasonable effort should be made to let us know that you're unable to meet a stated deadline.

Note that the *Faculty/Staff Handbook "Attendance Expectations and Official Absence Policy"* section states that "Faculty are required to permit students to make up work missed because of Official University Absences." If you will have an Official University Absence, please make arrangements with us in advance to make up the missed work.

Participation, Engagement & Attendance

For us, our course material is best learned through conversation and hands-on practice, not lecture. The experience of any course comes not from the purported "brilliance" of the professors but from the engagement and trust of the broader classroom community. Trust develops over time spent in each other's company.

In keeping with our Ungrading policy, we will not "grade you" on attendance and have no official attendance policy. But please understand, it is our responsibility to keep track of your participation in the various elements of the course 1) to make sure everyone is making steady progress and 2) for reference should you have a grade appeal at the end of the term.

Please also understand that infrequent attendance could also affect the persuasiveness of the arguments you make for your midterm and semester grades.

Beyond that, we refer you to The *University Attendance Policy* that regular and punctual class attendance is essential and that no assigned work is excused because of absence, no matter what the cause.

Participation

Given the hands-on and potentially collaborative nature of the work we'll do together this semester, active and earnest participation is one of our baseline expectations. You'll learn a lot from the course's instructors. You'll learn even more from each other. The quality and consistency of your participation and engagement with the course community will be something you'll want to discuss in your 2 course reflections as you build a case for your semester grade.

Because it is considered an infringement on student privacy for me to have access to student medical records, I cannot accept medical documentation to justify absences. If you have a legitimate reason for your absence and want to provide verification, please access the Absence Documentation Form here.

Lack of distinction between Excused Absences and Verified Absences. Excused Absences or Official University Absences are absences described in the Official University Absence Policy and include the following: Title IX related issues, military leave, holy days, and university related absences. As faculty we may not penalize students for these absences and must allow for the completion of assignments and exams within a reasonable amount of time after the absences. Beyond these, faculty retain all discretion for consideration of a student's absence, including verified absences.

Course Assignments & Final Grade

Self-Reflection 1	CLO 3
Lab 1	CLO 1
Lab 2	CLO 2
Lab 3	CLO 1
Lab 4	CLO 1
Lab 5	CLO 2
Lab 6	CLO 1
Skill Portfolio & Midsemester Reflection	CLO 2, 3
Project Proposal	CLO 1, 3
Semester Project & Final Reflection	CLO 1,2, 3

Note: Remember, this course will focus on qualitative as opposed to quantitative assessment. As a result, the assignments do not carry traditional point or percentage weights.

Grading Scale(s)

Option: Plus/Minus	
Grade	**Undergraduate**
A	94–100
A-	90–93.99
B+	87–89.99
B	84–86.99
B-	80–83.99
C+	77–79.99
C	74–76.99
C-	70–73.99
D+	67–69.99
D	64–66.99

Option: Plus/Minus	
Grade	**Undergraduate**
D-	60–63.99
F	0–59.99

Course Policies

Technology Policies

Artificial Intelligence (AI) Ethical Considerations and Consequences for Misuse
The inappropriate or unauthorized use of AI-generated content may be academic misconduct and/or a violation of discipline-specific professional ethics. Such misuse of AI or other assignment-help tools will be handled according to TCU's Academic Conduct Policy or other relevant policies and may result in sanctions, including failing the course, program dismissal, suspension, or expulsion.

Course Policy Regarding AI:

Artificial intelligence may be used for any assignment with appropriate citation. Examples of such citations can be found online, for example at APA. You are responsible for fact-checking statements composed by AI. The use of AI should not replace your critical thinking, judgment, and topic expertise.

COURSE SCHEDULE

PLEASE REFER TO OUR D2L COURSE SHELL FOR THE MOST RECENT AND UPDATED COURSE SCHEDULE